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From the editor-in-chief

Picking the Newsmaker of the Year is usually a very straightforward exercise: our newsmaker by definition is always the person, or persons, dominating the headlines over a year, who through his actions manages to set or alter the national agenda.

The year 2008 was full of news and newsmakers: political activity was hectic, the UPA Government had its strength tested in Parliament, its leader Manmohan Singh supported and oversaw the successful signing of the Indo-US nuclear deal. This year, even as the stock exchange rose and plummeted, the world's cheapest car was displayed, India won its first individual Olympic gold and we even sent a mission to the moon.

But over and above all other news, no matter how controversial or promising, 2008 was a year when India was held hostage by terror. We carried eight cover stories on terror this year. It began on January 1, with a Lashkar attack on a CRPF camp in Uttar Pradesh and virtually every month in 2008, news came in of a fresh outrage. By the time 2008 drew to a close with Mumbai's 60 hours of horror, India had lost 434 of its citizens in nine major terror attacks. They took place in all corners of our country and in all our major cities: Delhi, Mumbai, Bangalore, Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Agartala and Guwahati. This does not include the continuing insurgencies in Kashmir and the North-east which claimed 1,157 lives this year. Be it the rich or the poor, terrorism affected all our lives.

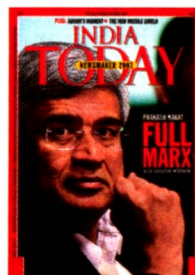
As the months wore on, the death toll rose but the response from the state was both blundering and inadequate. Every passing incident reminded Indians of their vulnerability as citizens of a state that can't protect its own. The Mumbai attack may just become the watershed event in India's war against terror. Terrorism now dominates the national debate and it could, more or less, decide the fate of the next general election.

Naturally, there was no doubt in our mind as to who had been the biggest newsmaker of the year. It was the faceless, anonymous terrorist, who seemed to be everywhere and yet, when it came down to hunting him down, nowhere. Who moved about freely and struck at will. Who may look like most young men on the street wearing T-shirts and jeans and carrying backpacks, but was so fiercely indoctrinated that he saw killing innocents as an act of heroism. Who gave to India devastation, death and a sense of national shame at our failure to stop him.

Our Newsmaker of the Year package takes you into the mind of the terrorist who held India hostage throughout 2008 and explains how and why he is able to operate so effectively all over the country.

I must admit that the choice of the terrorist as Newsmaker of 2008 has left us all with mixed feelings. It is, however, a reflection of the times we live in. At INDIA TODAY, we remember all too clearly that our first Newsmaker of the Year was Osama bin Laden in 2001. No one wants a terrorist to hijack the mindspace of a nation, but this is exactly what happened to India in 2008.

Let's hope 2009 is very, very different.



OUR 2007
NEWSMAKER

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)